

The Berlin Wall

The Berlin Wall was a guarded concrete barrier that divided West Berlin from East Berlin and the surrounding East Germany from 13 August 1961 to 9 November 1989. Construction was ordered by East German leader Walter Ulbricht and implemented by Erich Honecker.

The wall was built by the German Democratic Republic (GDR) to prevent its citizens from fleeing to West Germany via West Berlin. Between 1949 and 1961, about 2.5 million East Germans had fled, many of them young and educated.

President John F. Kennedy visited West Berlin on 26 June 1963 and delivered his "Ich bin ein Berliner" speech in front of the Rathaus Schöneberg. President Ronald Reagan visited on 12 June 1987 and challenged Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev to "tear down this wall".

The wall fell on 9 November 1989 after East German spokesman Günter Schabowski mistakenly announced that travel restrictions were lifted "immediately" during a press conference. German reunification took place on 3 October 1990.